

While their name is on the big marquee sign, many agents work with a team, so they may not be the person you are spending time with. If that's important to you, make sure you know up front who will actually be showing you houses.

How many clients do you have right now? Will you have time for me?

With a big, recognizable name comes a lot of clients. Does the agent you're working with really have the time to take on one more?

Am I required to sign an exclusivity agreement?

Most agents will say yes, and that's not a problem. An exclusivity agreement means that you will work with this agent and *only* this agent—basically, you won't needlessly bail on them for someone else.

If you do sign with this agent, make sure you read the document carefully and either ask them for clarification or get an attorney to clarify for you. In many of these agreements, a success fee is earned when you buy a house. No big deal. You don't work for free, and you can't expect your agent to work for free either. However, if you don't use the agent with whom you signed an agreement, you may still owe them a commission. You definitely want to catch this potentially multi-thousand-dollar mistake before you sign anything.

If I sign a contract with you to represent me and things don't work out, how do I cancel that contract?

This one is important. Despite your best efforts, you may decide to start a relationship with an agent that doesn't work out. You want an easy-to-cancel contract, not a runaround when you're already annoyed with the person. Try to get this answer in writing.

It might take a few weeks to find the perfect agent, so don't sweat it if you don't find the right person for a while. You don't want to settle for anything less than exactly what you need.

A great agent for a first-time home buyer will be understanding and supportive of your specific goals and timeline for your purchase. They will give you honest, expert feedback on your research and offer their opinion on whether what you are looking for is reasonable. They will be communicative and responsive at all times throughout your journey, and